

Can an AI Assistant Generate True Phước During Ritual Chanting?

Why Are We Talking About This Topic?

Chanting, Pagodas, and the Meaning of Phước

When picturing Vietnam, images of majestic pagodas and the rhythmic, sacred sound of monks chanting always come to a person's mind. For centuries, chanting monks have been a familiar presence, and they have long become a part of Vietnamese culture. For a Vietnamese person, chanting and pagodas are used as a way to show devotion and generate Phước. In Vietnamese Buddhism, Phước is the spiritual merit that shapes karma and brings peace to a person's relatives. Because this tradition relies on an individual's inner intent, any change to the way chanting is done could alter a person's Phước.

The Arrival of the Robot Novice

In 2019, a major development altered Vietnam's tradition of chanting. More specifically, during the Lunar New Year events at the Giac Ngo Pagoda in Ho Chi Minh City, the temple officially introduced an artificial intelligence assistant called Robot Chu Tieu Giac Ngo 4.0 (Hạnh Ý). A local biological robotics research team led by Dr. Nguyen Ba Hai designed this machine to help the community learn about Buddhist teachings (Hạnh Ý). Additionally, the robot also proved its own capabilities by reciting more than 100 different Buddhist sutras and answering roughly 3,000 questions about Buddhist philosophy (Hạnh Ý). The primary goal of this new robot is to provide a helpful tool to share religious knowledge with lay Buddhists who want to learn about the dharma (Hạnh Ý).

What Is Lost

Despite the advantages of the chanting robot, it can introduce a massive philosophical problem. To be more specific, a person should look more closely at what they lose when they accept the use of AI robot monks. When technology takes over practices such as chanting, it alters the fundamental nature of rituals. Therefore, we have to think about whether a technical device can actually produce spiritual merit or whether it damages the value created from chanting traditions.

The Intention Argument

Vasubandhu on Karma as Volition

The first compelling argument comes from the ideas of Vasubandhu, a famous ancient Buddhist philosopher. Vasubandhu spent his life analyzing karma in his masterwork, the *Abhidharmakośa*. Vasubandhu argued that

karma is not just a physical action a person can perform with their body or words. Instead, he stated that karma is fundamentally related to the intention of a person (Vasubandhu). In his philosophy, an action only carries spiritual weight if there is a conscious choice and a purposeful thought behind it. For example, if a person steps on an insect unintentionally, he or she does not create bad karma because the mind did not intend it.

Applying Vasubandhu's philosophy to the robotic monk at Giac Ngo Pagoda reveals a major problem within the system. To be more specific, the automated assistant can play the exact sounds of a sutra perfectly, but it lacks the capacity for thought. Namely, the robot does not have feelings or any awareness of the chanting lines that it produces. This is because the robot is running lines of computer code that trigger audio files instead of possessing intentions or having a conscious choice when saying chanting lines. On the other hand, in traditional chanting, the monk engages in the conscious act of directing their mental energy to bring good karma to relatives or deceased family members. Because of this, Vasubandhu's framework suggests that when we use machines to replicate chanting lines, it strips away human volition, which makes the generation of Phước meaningless (Vasubandhu).

The Engagement Argument

Borgmann on the Device Paradigm

Another relevant argument stems from the work of Albert Borgmann, a modern philosopher who studies how machines change human behavior. Borgmann developed the concept known as the device paradigm. More specifically, Borgmann states that everyday life is filled with deep activities that he calls focal practices (Borgmann). A focal practice is something that takes effort and patience in order to carry out, such as cooking a traditional meal from scratch or participating in a long religious ceremony. These practices are extremely important because they compel a person to engage with the things around them and build personal character.

Albert Borgmann adds that modern technology usually replaces deep activities with devices. Additionally, with the implementation of technology in our daily lives, devices are now capable of giving us a final product instantly without making a person do any of the hard work. For example, a microwave gives a person a reward of hot food without actually having to cook, and a heating vent provides a person with warmth without having to work for it (Borgmann). Similarly, for chanting, part of what gives chanting spiritual weight is that monks usually spend years mastering complicated sutras, which requires a significant amount of patience and effort. Therefore, when we let robots conduct chants, we are treating spiritual merit produced from chanting as a reward a person could achieve without any effort or patience. Borgmann's philosophy warns us that when technology makes a sacred practice effortless, we unintentionally destroy the discipline that makes the activity meaningful in the first place (Borgmann).

Counterpoint: Interdependence and the Listener's Mind

Hongladarom on Anattā and Dependent Origination

With the acknowledgement that there are disadvantages to using AI for chanting, Soraj Hongladarom, a modern scholar who studies the intersection of Eastern philosophy and artificial intelligence, offers an alternate point of view. Hongladarom argues that in Buddhist philosophy, nothing in the universe exists entirely on its own. There is no permanent, isolated soul or self in any object or person, a doctrine known as Anattā. Instead, everything is part of a massive, interconnected web of causes and effects called dependent origination (Hongladarom).

The Robot as a Catalyst

Under Hongladarom's view, it matters little whether the chanting robot has a mind or an independent soul. The reason behind this is that neither a human monk nor a machine possesses a permanent, isolated self, so the robot does not need to generate Phước by itself. Instead, the technology acts as a catalyst that helps listeners facilitate the process of generating Phước from their own minds. To be more specific, when a person sits in the temple and hears the automated voice recite the words of the Buddha, that sound enters his or her ears and acts as an external condition that changes his or her thoughts. It reminds the listener to be kind, helps that person manage stress, and encourages reflection on moral duties. In other words, a person's mind is what generates positive karma rather than the robot itself. Consequently, Hongladarom's argument shows that an AI assistant can be a valid tool to use in a spiritual environment because it functions with the intention to stimulate mindfulness in a listener (Hongladarom).

Conclusion

Where Merit Might Originate

Bringing all these philosophical views together shows that evaluating robotic chanting is not just about pros and cons, but rather the question: where does spiritual merit actually originate? On one side, famous philosophers such as Vasubandhu argued that robot chanting systems lack any intentions, meaning that incorporating automated chanting robots does not add any spiritual value. Furthermore, Albert Borgmann pointed out that robot chanting technology eliminates the patience, effort, and sacrifice that monks have to make in order to memorize sutras and chanting lines, which destroys the values of sutras and chanting. On the other hand, scholars such as Soraj Hongladarom contend that as long as chanting robots help listeners generate Phước, they do not necessarily need to have intentions to be beneficial.

Ultimately, whether an AI assistant generates true Phước depends on how a person defines the boundary of ritual. To be more precise, an AI algorithm is not capable of having the intentional mind or the discipline of a traditional monk. However, if we view the AI monk as a tool that evokes a person's mindfulness, then the technology can still guide a person towards positive karma. Consequently, with the constant development of

AI, communities have to decide whether spiritual merit originates in the source that produces the chant or in the mind of the person listening to it.

Works Cited

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